APEX DIVISION

REACH YOUR PEAK WITH APEX DIVISION

IRON FOUNDATIONS · 2026 EDITION

APEX DIVISION POWERLIFTING

IRON FOUNDATIONS

THE COMPLETE POWERLIFTING BLUEPRINT

10	5	RPE	ALL
WEEKS	DAYS / WEEK	LOADING SYSTEM	LEVELS

Built for the athlete who is serious about the barbell. No fluff, no guesswork — just a proven system to build real strength from the ground up.

PROGRAM INDEX

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WHO THIS IS FOR

BUILT FOR THE SERIOUS ATHLETE.

Iron Foundations is a 10-week RPE-based powerlifting program designed for athletes at every level — from someone touching a competition-style program for the first time, to an intermediate lifter looking to break through a plateau and build a real strength base.

This isn't a program for someone who wants to dabble. This is for the person who shows up, does the work, and trusts the process even when it gets uncomfortable. If that's you — you're in the right place.

WHAT THIS PROGRAM WILL DO FOR YOU

Build a technically sound, powerful squat, bench, and deadlift. Develop the accessory strength to support your big three for years. Learn how to train by feel using the RPE system — the same method used by elite powerlifters worldwide. And give you a complete peaking experience with a mock meet in week 10.

THE PROGRAM WORKS BECAUSE

- **Autoregulation via RPE** — you train based on how your body actually feels that day, not arbitrary percentages
- **Frequency matters** — you squat twice, bench three times, and deadlift twice per week
- **Built-in deloads** — recovery is programmed, not optional
- **Accessory work** — every weakness that limits the big three gets addressed directly
- **Real peaking** — week 10 simulates a meet so you know exactly where you stand

WHAT YOU NEED

- **A barbell and plates** — this is a barbell-first program
- **A squat rack** — non-negotiable
- **A bench** — flat bench required
- **Basic accessories** — cables, dumbbells, bands for accessory work
- **A lifting belt** — recommended from week 5 onward on heavy sets
- **Chalk** — for deadlifts especially

LOADING SYSTEM

UNDERSTANDING RPE.

RPE stands for Rate of Perceived Exertion. Instead of telling you to lift a specific percentage of your max, RPE tells you **how hard a set should feel**. This is how the best powerlifters in the world train — and for good reason. Your strength fluctuates daily based on sleep, stress, nutrition, and recovery. RPE accounts for all of that.

6	7	8	9	10
EASY	MODERATE	HARD	VERY HARD	MAX EFFORT
4+ reps left in tank. Moves fast, no strain.	3 reps left. Challenging but controlled.	2 reps left. Tough but form is solid.	1 rep left. Form slightly slows — max effort near.	True max. Could not have done another rep.

HOW TO READ PROGRAM NOTATION

4 × 3 @ RPE 8 means 4 sets of 3 reps, where the last set should feel like an 8 out of 10. Start lighter and build up — your top set of that session should hit RPE 8. Back-off sets stay at the same weight unless noted otherwise.

COMMON RPE MISTAKES

- **Going too heavy too soon** — week 1 should feel almost too easy. Trust it.
- **Ignoring form breakdown** — if form breaks down before your target RPE, that is your actual RPE
- **Sandbagging** — RPE 8 should be genuinely hard, not comfortable
- **Not logging** — write down every weight used so you can track RPE accuracy over time

RPE GETS EASIER WITH TIME

- Beginners often overestimate RPE early on — that's normal
- By week 3 to 4 your accuracy will sharpen significantly
- Use a training log to match weights to RPE scores each session
- If a session feels unexpectedly hard — train to the RPE, not the weight

10 WEEK OVERVIEW

PROGRAM STRUCTURE.

Iron Foundations runs across three distinct training blocks, each with a specific purpose. Every four weeks of building is followed by a deload week to consolidate strength gains and keep your body healthy. The program finishes with a dedicated peak and mock meet week.

01

ACCUMULATION BLOCK

WEEKS 1-4

Higher volume, moderate intensity. RPE targets stay between 7 and 8. The goal here is building work capacity, technical consistency, and a strong foundation. Week 4 is a deload — reduce all sets to 60% of normal volume.

02

INTENSIFICATION BLOCK

WEEKS 5-8

Volume drops, intensity rises. RPE targets climb to 8 and 9. Heavier weights, lower rep ranges on the main movements. Accessory work stays consistent. Week 8 is a deload — same protocol as week 4.

03

PEAK & MOCK MEET BLOCK

WEEKS 9-10

Week 9 is your final heavy week — openers and second attempts practiced. Week 10 is your mock meet. You will attempt a true 1 rep max on squat, bench, and deadlift under competition-style conditions. This is what you've been building toward.

WEEKLY LAYOUT

DAY	FOCUS	PRIMARY	VOLUME
MONDAY	Squat Day — Primary	Competition Squat	High
TUESDAY	Accessory Day — Upper	Bench Variation	Moderate
WEDNESDAY	Bench Day — Primary	Competition Bench	High
THURSDAY	Rest / Active Recovery	—	Rest
FRIDAY	Deadlift Day — Primary	Competition Deadlift	High
SATURDAY	Accessory Day — Lower	Squat Variation	Moderate
SUNDAY	Full Rest	—	Rest

WEEKS 1-4 · ACCUMULATION BLOCK

THE FULL PROGRAM.

Below is the complete daily breakdown for all 10 weeks. RPE targets are listed for each main movement. Accessory work uses rep ranges — work to a challenging but controlled effort, leaving 2 to 3 reps in reserve on all accessory sets.

MON SQUAT — PRIMARY DAY

COMPETITION SQUAT FOCUS · HIGH VOLUME · WEEKS 1-4 TARGETS SHOWN

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
Competition Squat *Main movement — competition stance and depth*	Wk1: 4×5 Wk2: 4×4 Wk3: 5×3 Wk4: 3×5 (deload)	RPE 7 RPE 8 RPE 8 RPE 6	3-4 min	Build to top set, 2 back-off sets same weight
Pause Squat *2 second pause at the bottom — no bounce*	3×3	RPE 7	2-3 min	Approx 75-80% of main squat weight
Romanian Deadlift *Hamstring and glute accessory*	3×8-10	Controlled	2 min	Full stretch at bottom, no rounding
Leg Press *Quad accessory — moderate foot placement*	3×10-12	Controlled	90 sec	Full range, don't lock out at top
Plank or Ab Wheel *Core stability work*	3×30-60 sec	Challenging	60 sec	Brace hard, don't let hips sag

TUE UPPER ACCESSORY DAY

BENCH VARIATION + UPPER BODY ACCESSORY · MODERATE VOLUME

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
Close Grip Bench Press *Tricep strength and bench lockout work*	4×6	RPE 7	2–3 min	Hands shoulder width, controlled descent
Incline Dumbbell Press *Upper chest and shoulder accessory*	3×10–12	Controlled	90 sec	30–45 degree incline
Barbell or Cable Row *Upper back — critical for bench stability*	4×8–10	Controlled	90 sec	Squeeze at top, don't use momentum
Tricep Pushdowns *Cable — straight bar or rope*	3×12–15	Pump	60 sec	Full extension, controlled return
Face Pulls *Rear delt and rotator cuff health*	3×15–20	Light	60 sec	Pull to face level, external rotation at end
Bicep Curls *Elbow flexor health and arm strength*	3×12	Pump	60 sec	Any variation — barbell, dumbbell, cable

WED BENCH — PRIMARY DAY

COMPETITION BENCH FOCUS · HIGH VOLUME · WEEKS 1-4 TARGETS SHOWN

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
Competition Bench Press *Full competition setup — arch, leg drive, pause optional*	Wk1: 4×5 Wk2: 4×4 Wk3: 5×3 Wk4: 3×5 (deload)	RPE 7 RPE 8 RPE 8 RPE 6	3–4 min	Touch chest, full lockout, controlled descent
Pause Bench Press *2 second pause on chest — builds starting strength*	3×4	RPE 7	2–3 min	Approx 80% of main bench weight

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
Dumbbell Bench Press *Chest accessory — full range of motion*	3×10–12	Controlled	90 sec	Deep stretch at bottom
Lat Pulldown *Lat strength — improves bar path and stability*	3×10–12	Controlled	90 sec	Full stretch at top, pull elbows to ribs
Overhead Tricep Extension *Long head tricep — lockout strength*	3×12–15	Pump	60 sec	Cable or dumbbell — full extension

FRI DEADLIFT — PRIMARY DAY

COMPETITION DEADLIFT FOCUS · HIGH VOLUME · WEEKS 1-4 TARGETS SHOWN

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
Competition Deadlift *Your stance — conventional or sumo*	Wk1: 4×4 Wk2: 4×3 Wk3: 5×2 Wk4: 3×3 (deload)	RPE 7 RPE 8 RPE 8 RPE 6	3–5 min	Reset between reps — no touch and go
Deficit Deadlift *Stand on 1–2 inch plate — builds off-floor strength*	3×3	RPE 7	3 min	70–75% of competition deadlift weight
Barbell Hip Thrust *Glute strength — lockout power*	3×10–12	Controlled	90 sec	Full hip extension at top, pause briefly
Pendlay Row or Chest Supported Row *Upper back strength for pulling position*	4×6–8	Controlled	2 min	Explosive pull, controlled return
Leg Curl *Hamstring isolation accessory*	3×12–15	Pump	60 sec	Lying or seated — full range
Farmer Carries or Suitcase Carry *Grip strength and core stability*	3×40m	Heavy	90 sec	Tall posture, controlled steps

SAT LOWER ACCESSORY DAY

SQUAT VARIATION + LOWER BODY ACCESSORY · MODERATE VOLUME

EXERCISE	SETS × REPS	RPE / LOAD	REST	NOTES
High Bar Squat or Front Squat *Quad dominant variation — builds raw strength*	4×5	RPE 7	2–3 min	More upright torso than competition squat
Walking Lunges *Single leg strength and stability*	3×10 each	Controlled	90 sec	Bodyweight or light dumbbells
Good Mornings *Posterior chain — lower back and hamstrings*	3×10–12	Light	90 sec	Keep light — focus on hip hinge movement
Seated Calf Raises *Ankle stability and lower leg strength*	3×15–20	Pump	60 sec	Full range, slow return
Cable Pull-Through or Banded Hip Hinge *Glute and hamstring activation*	3×15	Pump	60 sec	Drive hips forward at lockout

WEEKS 5-8 — INTENSIFICATION BLOCK ADJUSTMENTS

In the intensification block all main movement sets reduce by one set and rep targets drop. Squat: 4×3 @ RPE 8–9 building to 3×2 @ RPE 9 in week 7. Bench: 4×3 @ RPE 8–9 building to 3×2 @ RPE 9. Deadlift: 4×2 @ RPE 8–9 building to 3×1 @ RPE 9. Accessory work volume stays the same. Week 8 deload same protocol as week 4 — drop all sets to 60% volume at RPE 6.

FUELING STRENGTH

NUTRITION FOR POWERLIFTING.

You cannot out-train a bad diet. For powerlifting specifically, your nutrition strategy has one primary goal — fuel performance and recovery. This is not a fat loss program. If you want to get stronger, you need to eat enough to support that. Here's how to do it right.

CALCULATE YOUR BASELINE CALORIES

Take your bodyweight in pounds and multiply by 16 to 18 to get your estimated maintenance calories. If you are losing weight while running this program, eat more. If performance is suffering and recovery is poor, eat more. Strength programs demand fuel — don't undercut yourself.

1G	40–50%	25–35%
PER LB BODYWEIGHT	OF TOTAL CALORIES	OF TOTAL CALORIES
PROTEIN	**CARBOHYDRATES**	**FATS**

BEST PROTEIN SOURCES

- Chicken breast or thighs
- Lean ground beef or steak
- Eggs and egg whites
- Greek yogurt and cottage cheese
- Whey or casein protein powder
- Tuna, salmon, white fish

BEST CARB SOURCES

- White rice — fast digesting, easy on the gut
- Oats — pre-workout fuel
- Sweet potato — training day staple
- Pasta and bread for high calorie needs
- Fruit — easy carbs, great pre-training
- Potatoes — versatile, dense carb source

MEAL TIMING FOR POWERLIFTING

Pre-training (1–2 hours before): Carb and protein focused meal. Rice and chicken, oats and eggs, pasta and meat. You need fuel in the tank before heavy sets.

Post-training (within 1–2 hours after): High protein and carb meal to start recovery. This is the most important meal of your training day.

Before bed: Casein protein or cottage cheese — slow digesting protein feeds muscle repair overnight.

STAYING HEALTHY

RECOVERY & INJURY PREVENTION.

The program does the work. Sleep and recovery do the growing. Five days of heavy training is a significant load on your body — this section is not optional reading.

NON-NEGOTIABLES

- **Sleep 7 to 9 hours** — this is when strength adaptations actually happen. No shortcuts.
- **Drink 0.5 to 1 gallon of water daily** — hydration directly impacts strength and recovery
- **Eat enough** — chronic undereating will stall progress and increase injury risk
- **Warm up properly** — never jump straight to working weight on the big three
- **Respect the deload** — week 4 and 8 feel easy by design. Don't skip them.

WARM UP PROTOCOL

- **5 min light cardio** — raise heart rate and body temperature
- **Hip flexor and hip circle stretches** — for squat and deadlift days
- **Band pull-aparts and shoulder circles** — for bench days
- **Activation sets** — empty bar × 10, 50% × 5, 70% × 3, 85% × 1 before working sets
- **Never skip activation** — your first working set should feel familiar, not shocking

COMMON INJURIES & HOW TO AVOID THEM

Lower back: Almost always caused by rounding on deadlift or losing brace on squat. Film yourself. Brace before you pull or descend — every single rep.

Shoulder: Often from flared elbows on bench or skipping face pulls. Keep elbows at 45–75 degrees on bench descent. Do your face pulls — they're not optional.

Knee: Usually from poor squat depth control or knees caving. Track your knees over your toes. Strengthen your adductors with sumo stance work.

If something hurts — not soreness, actual sharp pain — stop that movement and contact your coach immediately.

THE FINALE

PEAK WEEK & MOCK MEET.

This is what the last 9 weeks have been building toward. Week 10 is your mock meet — a simulation of a real powerlifting competition where you will attempt a true 1 rep max on all three lifts. Follow the protocol exactly. Trust your preparation.

WEEK 9 — OPENER WEEK

Week 9 is not a max effort week. It is your final heavy week before the peak. **Monday:** Squat opener attempt — a weight you could triple on your worst day. **Wednesday:** Bench opener attempt — same protocol. **Friday:** Deadlift opener attempt. Keep all sets to 1 to 2 reps, RPE 8 maximum. No new maxes this week. Save it.

W10 MOCK MEET — WEEK 10

ATTEMPT YOUR TRUE 1 REP MAX ON ALL THREE LIFTS · COMPETITION CONDITIONS

LIFT	ATTEMPT 1 — OPENER	ATTEMPT 2 — SECOND	ATTEMPT 3 — MAX	NOTES
Squat *Monday or Day 1*	90–92% of expected max Must be a guaranteed make	95–97% of expected max Challenging but confident	True max attempt Go for the PR	Rest 15–20 min between attempts
Bench Press *Wednesday or Day 2*	90–92% of expected max	95–97% of expected max	True max attempt	Competition pause — touch and wait
Deadlift *Friday or Day 3*	90–92% of expected max	95–97% of expected max	True max attempt	Reset between reps — competition style

MOCK MEET DAY RULES

- Eat a full meal 2 to 3 hours before — carb heavy
- Warm up exactly as you have all program
- Only attempt a third lift if your second was a clean make
- No more than 3 attempts per lift
- Record every attempt on video — review your technique
- Celebrate every PR — this is what you trained for

AFTER THE MOCK MEET

- Take 1 full week off or at absolute minimum effort
- Eat at or above maintenance — you earned it
- Review your video — note what needs work
- Consider entering a real sanctioned meet — you're ready
- Contact your Apex Division coach for next program recommendations

TRACK EVERYTHING

YOUR PROGRESS TRACKER.

Log your top set weight for each main movement every week. Watching this table fill up is one of the most motivating things in training. Numbers don't lie.

LIFT	WK 1	WK 2	WK 3	WK 4	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8	WK 9	WK 10 MAX
SQUAT										
BENCH										
DEADLIFT										
TOTAL										

ALSO TRACK WEEKLY

Bodyweight every Monday morning (fasted). Sleep hours per night. Energy level 1–10 each session. Any nagging pains or discomfort. The more data you collect, the better you and your coach can make decisions about your training.

APEX DIVISION

STRENGTH IS BUILT IN THE DARK.

Nobody sees the 5am sessions. Nobody sees the weeks where everything felt heavy and you showed up anyway. Nobody sees the discipline it takes to follow a program when you want to go rogue.

But the barbell keeps score. And 10 weeks from now, when you step up to that mock meet and hit numbers you didn't think were possible — that's yours. Nobody can take it.

Trust the process. Trust the program. Do the work.

— APEX DIVISION COACHING